Class #2 -

Instructions

Navigate to the slide labelled with your number

Design a slide as follows:

- identify a piece of conventional wisdom around strategy in some area of life (business, government, arts, sports, games, warfare, …)
- state a proposition (a new strategy) that stands in sharp contrast with this conventional wisdom
- produce a mini-presentation arguing that the new approach could work

Group 1: Rachel, Mario, Uka, Ailin, Katharina, Emily

Conventional wisdom: "Keep your friends close, and your enemies closer"

- New strategy: "Protect your peace"
- Spending energy managing an asset that's not valuable is wasted energy, takes away from your ability to be your best self
- Not voicing the reality of a problem inhibits you from the chance to find a better solution or the chance for a true ally or asset
- Two-Faced = unethical (personal preference)

Group 2: Nicole T., Gregory M., Adam Kovler, Yutong Wu, Katherine B., David Z., Darrel Lung

“The customer is always right.”

(The market / the data is the solution product)

Contrasting Proposition: Customers are wrong about the solution, but right about the problems.

Approach: Listen for insight to interpret, challenge the customer (market / data). Ask questions and spend time to understand the problem. Take a creative path to form solution rather than directly follow customers’ instinct.

Group 3: Parnika,Rohan Yellamilli, Jordan Guillory, Rhema Obiefuna, Jasmitha Pissay Narayana, Isabella Cai, Audrey Green

Conventional Wisdom:
Building the plane while its in the air + build fast and break things

Metaverse fail with 80 billion dollar loss
Good for first movers advantage but this strategy does not allow for large strategic shifts at scale and impact to be made which can result in expensive losses for all teams involved

Counter Strategy:
Build rails before speed, measure twice cut once

Ex: Airbnb -> tested the idea before scaling globally

Group 4: Utsav Doshi, Shipra Dagli, Jay Daftari, Siddh Mandirwala

Stop hiring the smartest people in the room.

Hire the most *bored* ones.

Conventional wisdom

"A-players attract A-players. Hire for raw complex IQ."

The proposition

Hire people who are overqualified and quietly itching to do something insane with it.

Uncomfortable truths

- **Stewart Butterfield** : philosophy grad, built Flickr, sold it to Yahoo
- Got bored inside Yahoo's bureaucracy, left
- Built a game called *Glitch* : flopped and shut down in 2012
- His team had built an internal chat tool just to communicate while making the game
- Game died, chat tool survived : he pivoted and called it Slack.
- Valued at $7B within a few years, sold to Salesforce for $27.7B

A satisfied person stays at Yahoo. Boredom built Slack.

Group 5: Parker Dawson, Annabel Miller Green, Luke Lamble, Tatiana Donald, Harshini Vijaya Kumar

- Conventional wisdom: Specific qualifications e.g. years of experience, certain degrees, specific backgrounds, etc. are needed for specific roles
- New strategy: Lived experience will allow you to hire more well rounded people
- Why this approach would work: you can empathize with clients/customers if you have experienced something first hand
    - E.g. in design thinking - being able to empathize is essential to the process

Often degrees do not relate to your chosen career path

Group 6: Seth Weil, Sabrina Seneviratne, Ashley Bembry-Kaintuck, Laura Villano

- Conventional wisdom in sports is that a player should specialize in one position/role from a young age and develop expertise

- New strategy: Players should be more of a generalist early on to develop better knowledge of every position
  - By being exposed to different positions, roles, responsibilities and strategy, players will develop a more holistic understanding of the game — making them a more well-rounded player overall, but also more capable in their assigned position (e.g. goalie)

Group 7: Kat Kosiw, Campbell Killean, Ricky Baum, Amaan Nehru, Divya, Sreya Basuroy

Early bird catches the worm but it's always the second mouse that gets the cheese. (cheese > worm)

→ First to the market doesn't guarantee dominance
→ Companies going second have better opp to evaluate PMF and learn from failures of the first
→ take the existing (what already works), introduce a new element as diff
→ as a second mover, your only competition is the first, consumers appreciate choices (<4)

yahoo! → G

skype → zoom

OZEMPIC semaglutide injection 0.5mg, 1mg, 2mg → ONCE-WEEKLY wegovy®

Group 8: Sri, Javier, Abhipal, Rohan, Sahil

Conventional Wisdom: finding the Product Market Fit before launching the product

New Strategy: Launch the product and then find the market fit on the go

Why will it work:

1. **Customers never really know what they want** and launch reveals more about the customer mentality like what they actually use, ignore, pay for, and return to.
2. **Keeps the creative spark in the team by introducing faster learning loops and adaptibiliity to customer requirements ->** This is a value which might not been seen direct but beneficial in long run.

Example: Apple launching the new Iphone going against the norm back then - showing that they really cracked the user requirements.

Group 9: Joshua A., Shivam A., Michelle W.

Conventional Wisdom: “More options is a good thing”

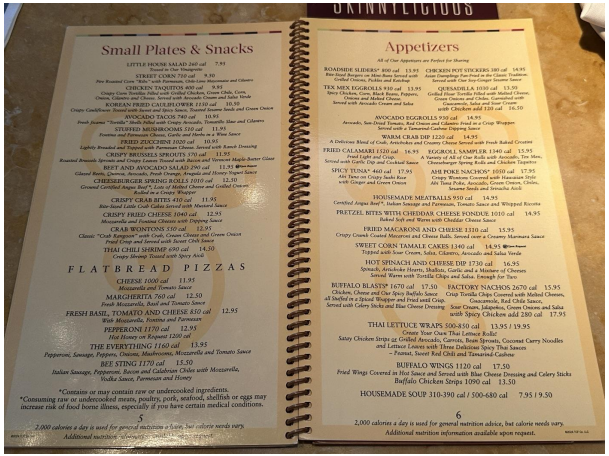
Rationale behind thinking:

- Having options to put the choice in your hands (not restricted in a box)

Counter Position: “There is value in limitation”

Rationale behind thinking:

- Limited choices bring higher detail to decision making



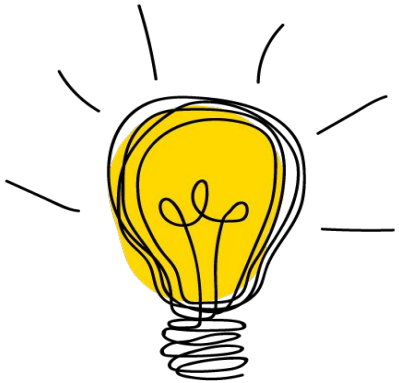
Group 10: Eugenia Igarza / Gonzalo Bardin / Shreya Jois / Lea Abbas / Sweda Rajaram

Conventional Wisdom: *Inspiration exists but it has to find you working - Pablo Picasso*

Counter Wisdom: Sometimes inspiration comes when you least expect it, without necessarily working on what it is you seek inspiration from.

Arguments in favor of counter wisdom:

- ➔ Inspiration can be a coincidence
- ➔ Inspiration can come from inexpertise
- ➔ Inspiration is everywhere



Group 11: Andrew Steelman, Gabriela Zappitelli, Ishika Sellers

Conventional Wisdom

The first mover advantage is the belief that being first to the market guarantees dominance, allows you to build the strongest brand recognition, and set industry standards

Counter-Proposition

- Allowing someone else to be the first mover, and make mistakes that come with doing something for the first time, will allow you to avoid these same mistakes when establishing a business.
- “Newer” may appear more modern or innovative than the original
- Can leverage market research that’s available from the first attempt to make different investment or strategy decisions

Examples:

myspace

2003

→

2004

1996

gm

→

TESLA

2008

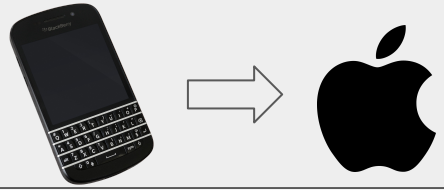
Group 12: Joy Chu, Olivia Burglund, Xueyao Zhao, Kavya Pratapa, Mark Shterk

Conventional wisdom: The customer is always right

Counterposition: The customer is *not always* right

Case 1: Developing something new

Customers do not know what they do not know, and often stay entrenched in their ways



Case 2: Bringing a product to market

The customer is focused on their own needs, rather than a mass-market product

Group 13: Emma Johnson, Mack Glavin, Jamie Varghese, Samantha Lutt, Matt Pulford

Conventional Wisdom: The countries that are spending more money/using high cost machinery have a military advantage

- *Example: The experts assumed Russia would take over Ukraine within 3-4 days*

New Proposition: Cheaper isn't always worse – Ukraine used innovative/low cost machinery and maritime drones to create untraceable signals – allowing it to neutralize and disrupt Russian forces

Group 14: Shreya Sukur & Pooja Patel

- Conventional Piece of Wisdom
  - “The customer is always right”
- A New Strategy
  - “The *right* customer- not every customer- is always right”
  - Serving the wrong customers hurts the business and the right customers
  - Businesses must push back on unreasonable demands
  - Prioritize high value, aligned customers

Group 15: Arnab Majumdar, Bernardo Linss, Ayesha Kirpalani, Prashubh Atri, Yan Li

Conventional Wisdom

- **The Strategy:** Turn inward to protect sovereignty.
- **The Tactics:** Shield local industries with tariffs and reject foreign "exploiter" corporations.
- **The Logic:** True independence requires being self-sufficient and keeping the world at a distance.

The New Proposition: The Global Plug-In (Lee Kuan Yee)

- **The Strategy:** Become indispensable to the global economy.
- **The Tactics:** Court multinationals, enforce "First World" order, and eliminate corruption with high government pay.
- **The Logic:** A tiny nation survives only if the world’s most powerful players cannot afford for it to fail.

“If you can't force or are unwilling to force your people to follow you, with or without threats, you are not a leader”- Lee Kuan Yee